Also, I used to visit Hotel Fort Manor with a few friends for an occasional drink. We would take our drink to the hotel and buy only water and snacks. Ahmed would refuse to take money from me, but I always insisted on paying my bill. Since Ahmed had instructed the waiters not to give me a bill, I used to get the bill directly from the counter and pay. The interrogators, having collected these bills, wondered why we bought only water and snacks.

Some of these bills the CBI found during their search of my home. And that explained why the CBI officers had called Ahmed. They asked us to identify each other and we did even exchange pleasantries. I told the officers about my visits, and that Ahmed used to take good care of the Russian scientists who stayed in his hotel. The officers bid Ahmed bye.

The day passed with intermittent inquiries by M L Sharma, P M Nair and P C Sharma. These were more of clarifications, and I was joining the dots myself: the CBI, even while carrying out its independent investigation, was sending out its people to interview and interrogate a large number of people mentioned in the IB report. I realised that by now the CBI had seen through the IB plot to fabricate a spicy international spy case. It was getting increasingly clear—to the CBI and me—that the IB's was not a slip, but a concerted effort to make up a conspiracy that never was. Was it for the high some lowly IB officers might have got from it? Or is there a bigger conspiracy? Clarity would soon emerge.

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8 December 1994. By 3pm, the Pallipuram camp became active. Officers were moving around with files, making clarifications and exchanging notes. One of the officers soon told me that CBI director K Vijaya Rama Rao was coming. An hour passed and an officer came to tell me that Rao wants to meet me.

I was taken to a room where sat a man in a white shirt, a blue suit and a matching tie. He stood up – quite tall, I thought—walked towards me with his hand in a pocket from where he fished out his ID card. 'I am K